

ERSATZREALITY × THYLORA

ORIGINAL STORY

Twelve Miles for Flour

An Uncle Seezin trail story about weather, pride, and bringing back what people actually need.

A finished digital edition. Print it, mark it up, or use it on screen.

A Simple Errand

Uncle Seezin said the trip was twelve miles. Caleb heard the number and decided it meant easy.

“Ride to Bell Crossing. Bring flour, lamp oil, salt, and the blue packet Mrs. Della left with the shopkeeper.”

Caleb leaned on the corral rail like a man posing for a picture nobody requested. “I can do that before supper.”

Seezin looked at a gray seam low in the western sky. “Take Isaiah.” “I do not need a nursemaid.” “Good. Isaiah ain’t one. Take him anyhow.”

The Road Chooses Too

The first six miles were dry and loud with grasshoppers. Caleb rode ahead. Isaiah kept a steady walk and checked the clouds whenever the wind went still.

At Dry Woman Creek the bridge leaned into brown water. Rain had fallen beyond the ridge and arrived before its clouds.

Caleb pointed upstream. “We can cross at the stones.” Isaiah watched water curl around them. “Those stones were visible last week.” “They are still there.” “So is the bottom. I do not plan to visit either.”

They turned south for the old freight ford, adding five miles.

Bell Crossing

By the time they reached the store, rain tapped the tin awning. Mr. Pruitt had one flour sack left and was saving it for the hotel. Caleb put down money. Mr. Pruitt pushed it back.

The door opened and a soaked woman entered carrying a child with a bleeding palm. Caleb reached for the flour. Isaiah reached for clean cloth.

They wrapped the child’s hand. The woman was the hotel owner. She divided the flour herself—some for four guests, the rest for the twenty-three people at camp—and added yeast.

Della's blue packet had left the day before on a freight wagon.

The Wagon in the Mud

They found the wagon two miles east, one wheel sunk to the hub. Driver Lottie James stood directing three men who had each decided not to hear her.

Caleb jumped down. "We can pull you free." Lottie looked at the wagon's angle. "You can pull my axle apart."

Isaiah asked what she needed. "Unload the left side, lay brush under the wheel, and let me drive my own team." They did. The wagon climbed out without breaking.

Lottie handed them Della's packet: medicine instructions and two photographs from her sister.

The Wrong Shortcut

At dusk Caleb chose a narrow ridge trail. It pointed home. For half a mile, that felt like wisdom. Then lightning split a dead cottonwood. The horses shied and the flour sack tore against a branch.

Isaiah caught it as flour leaked into the rain. Caleb stared. "Do not tell Seezin."

"Tell him what?" a voice called. Uncle Seezin rode from the dark leading a mule with empty grain tins. He had followed the storm.

He studied the sack and Caleb's face. "Road home is down there. This path is only pointed at it."

What They Brought Back

Seezin packed the flour into tins and led them by the longer drainage road. They reached camp after supper. Mrs. Della opened the blue packet with both hands. The photographs mattered most; she had not seen her sister's face in six years.

In the cook tent, Seezin measured enough flour for breakfast biscuits if mixed with cornmeal. Caleb waited for scolding. Seezin handed him a bowl. "Stir."

"That is all?" "No. Tomorrow you mend the sack, clean the tins, thank Isaiah, and draw the washed bridge on the route board."

Caleb stirred. "I thought twelve miles meant simple." Seezin said, "Distance tells you how far the road goes. Never told you what the road might do."

Breakfast

At dawn, biscuits browned in two iron pans. They were heavier than Seezin's usual and disappeared

faster.

Caleb carried the first plate to Isaiah. “Thank you.” “For what?” “For not letting me visit the bottom.” “Anytime.”

Outside, Seezin updated the supply list. Beside flour he wrote delivered. Beside route he wrote changed. Beside Caleb he wrote nothing.

Some things, he figured, needed another day before a man decided what they had become.

Talk together

What did Caleb think competence looked like at first?

Why did Isaiah ask questions instead of trying to win?

Which lines sound as though only Seezin, Isaiah, Caleb, or Lottie would say—and why?

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